

An Autoethnographic Reflection of Prompting a Custom GPT Based on Oneself

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ABSTRACT

What if you could have a chat with yourself? OpenAI's introduction of custom GPTs in November 2023 provides an opportunity for non-technical users to create specialized generative artificial intelligence chatbots. Users can write prompts in plain language rather than code to instruct how the system should behave. What can one learn from using non-technical methods to develop a specific chatbot persona? To explore this, I conducted an autoethnography of my experience developing and interacting with a custom GPT based on myself. My findings include a discussion of my experiences throughout the process, and its impact on my personal introspection and understanding of prompt engineering. I summarize first-hand challenges and insights intended to inspire further discussion on the topic of generative AI and chatbots.

CCS CONCEPTS

- **Computing methodologies** → **Natural language processing**;
- **Human-centered computing** → **Text input**.

KEYWORDS

autoethnography, generative artificial intelligence, large language model, chatbot, persona

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1 INTRODUCTION

"How can I help you today?" greets users upon opening a new chat with OpenAI's ChatGPT. Despite using a common line for digital assistants, ChatGPT has grown beyond the capabilities of a simple chatbot retrieving answers for the user. This generative artificial intelligence (AI) chatbot's rapid rise in popularity has sparked interdisciplinary discussions about AI and ethical controversies. Trained using text scraped from the internet [33], it faces challenges such as biases, misinformation, and copyright. Despite boasting over 100 million users [17], much of ChatGPT's internal workings remain largely undisclosed, inviting scrutiny to its lack of transparency.

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This one-month study serves as part of my preliminary research for future work relating to the use of custom generative AI chatbots based on realistic characteristics (e.g., personas). Therefore, it is important to consider how this type of system can be developed and identify challenges that may arise. The process can also serve as a useful learning experience for understanding the limitations of custom GPTs. Rather than designing a custom GPT based on any arbitrary persona, I base it on myself for several reasons. First, I would have the flexibility of creating my own knowledge sources. Second, I have extensive knowledge of myself and can evaluate the system's responses for plausibility. Third, I am curious what I can learn through the experience of dissecting my own identity into text prompts for an AI system to interpret. Furthermore, my motivation for using the system can change throughout the process.

As the personalization of AI becomes increasingly ubiquitous, further research is required on users' adoption of non-technical development methods (e.g., natural language prompt engineering [11, 24, 41]). Democratizing technology can have mixed consequences, including intentional misuse such as jailbreaking [15, 32, 39, 42]. In creating a digital representation of myself, I am curious about which aspects of my identity – such as demographics, personality, career, emotions, and ambitions – should be included, and how the system will interpret and convey this unique fusion of traits during conversation. This introspection can bring attention to conflicting representations of self (i.e., impression management in social media [35] compared to authentic personal diary statements).

There are few autoethnographic studies about ChatGPT. Existing autoethnographic research relating to the broader use of AI and discussing the experience are also few in number but include distinct topics of investigating accessibility-related uses for generative AI [12], chatbot-supported thesis writing [38], co-writing with AI [10], and conversing with ChatGPT [28]. According to Jones et al. [19], "autoethnography explicitly acknowledges, calls to and seeks contributions from audiences as part of the ongoing conversation of the work". I suggest reflecting on first-hand experiences of systems like ChatGPT can be useful in the context of personal introspection by providing an alternative perspective.

My exploratory research goal is to both develop and use a conversational agent that behaves plausibly based on my professional and personal experiences. Throughout an iterative creative approach to refine my chatbot, I used both publicly available information about myself and applied personal statements to guide the chatbot's behaviour. The findings represent my own subjective accounts in response to two main questions: (1) How can I create and use a custom GPT persona based on myself? (2) How does this experience influence my perspective of generative AI chatbots and myself (e.g., identity)? In this paper, I will discuss a summary of the process organized into different phases, challenges, and insights.

2 BACKGROUND

The public availability and accessibility of ChatGPT to the general population raises questions around its appropriate application. The notion that instructions can be given to the system via prompts written in plain language, removes the technical barrier to modifying an AI system. Instead, it requires new skills in prompt engineering, which involves the design, refinement, and implementation of prompts or instructions for large language models [41]. Moreover like other natural language models, ChatGPT can learn intersectional biases [20] and hallucinate, meaning it can generate misleading or inaccurate information that does not align with human expectations [18, 34]. By blending true and fabricated content, ChatGPT can write credible-sounding but unverified responses.

As OpenAI's implementation of custom GPTs was recently introduced in November 2023, there are currently few academic studies on this topic. However, there are already community users building and sharing over 3 million public GPTs with topics including creativity, research, programming, education, and lifestyle [31]. According to OpenAI, "GPTs are a new way for anyone to create a tailored version of ChatGPT to be more helpful in their daily life, at specific tasks, at work, or at home" and "Anyone can easily build their own GPT—no coding is required" [30]. The lack of detailed explanation about the technology's functioning makes it challenging to speculate on the specific techniques employed. For example, the ability to attach documents when building a custom GPT suggests a potential resemblance to retrieval-augmented generation (RAG). RAG grounds large language models by incorporating external, verifiable knowledge sources like documents, which can help to minimize inaccuracies [21].

3 METHODS

Autoethnography is defined as a personal narrative grounded in self-reflection [5] and used to "examine and/or critique cultural experience" [19]. Amid numerous technical investigations of ChatGPT, integrating the author's personal voice and analysis with broader social, cultural, and political contexts can foster meaningful discussions about the AI system's use. Ellis et al. [8] characterize autoethnography as "both process and product" – an apt duality as I examine both the development process and interactions with the resulting versions of a custom GPT based on myself. I frame my use of autoethnography as a way to report upon reflections within design-based research.

3.1 Positionality

Although I have some knowledge of AI systems and development, I would not consider myself an expert in this field. Regarding my perspective on AI, I am contemplative about its future applications. While I am optimistic of technological advancements and improvements to efficiency, I have ethical concerns and criticisms relating to its perceived functionality. I am investigating the non-technical creation and utilization of a custom GPT, for which I rely on myself as a subject matter expert on my own behaviours to assess the system's responses. Chatbots and digital assistants are often dependent on their domains and built for specific purposes; there is no universal framework for evaluating such diverse systems [2].

3.2 Custom GPTs

There is a distinction between ChatGPT and the underlying GPT model. I can still use OpenAI's GPT-4 large language model without using the ChatGPT platform via API. As GPT models continue to evolve, there will be changes to how prompts are interpreted. I chose to use ChatGPT based on its overwhelming popularity, but there are alternative approaches to creating a comparable custom GPT chatbot that may react differently to the same prompts.

OpenAI's platform enables non-technical users to create custom GPTs; I did not write any code and primarily prompted GPT Builder to update the system. Within the editor, GPT Builder is like a chatbot that helps the user create their custom GPT. In turn, a custom GPT is a chatbot customized by the user. When the user prompts GPT Builder, it generates instructions for the custom GPT's behaviour. The custom GPT's instructions can be seen on the Configure tab along with the name, description, and knowledge files (see Figure 1 in the Appendix). I will be distinguishing between *instructions* (prompt for the custom GPT's behaviour) and *prompts* (user inputs to get a response from the system) for more succinct language.

I followed prompt patterns described by White et al. [41]; the Persona Pattern is particularly relevant in this case (e.g., "Act as persona X"). I aimed to create a conversational agent that has adequate knowledge of my professional and personal experiences, and can behave accordingly. I did not expect it to act exactly like me, but it should behave in a human-like manner and provide plausible responses. Unfortunately, a limitation of this method is that OpenAI's GPT editor does not keep a log of chat history for neither GPT Builder nor the GPT test preview (see Figure 2 in the Appendix). Therefore, any documentation had to be completed manually.

3.3 Data Collection and Analysis

During the month-long study, I kept a digital diary to record my notes after each session with the custom GPT, which was interpreted with narrative analysis. This included a summary of what I did, what I learned from the interaction, and next steps for improvement. I also assessed the believability of responses according to three criteria: human-likeness, accurate information retrieval, and plausibility based on background knowledge. I transcribed the instructions for the custom GPT after each major change. Due to the reliance of custom GPTs on GPT-4, each session adhered to OpenAI's limit of 40 messages every 3 hours. This constraint often led to my sessions with the custom GPT being abruptly shortened or split across several hours. A cycle of the iterative process can be one session and can be summarized as: (1) select/generate knowledge sources (i.e., files to upload), (2) prompt GPT Builder to improve instructions, (3) test the custom GPT by chatting with it, (4) reflect in my digital diary about the process and conversations.

3.4 Limitations

OpenAI's ChatGPT is but one company's implementation of a generative AI system, and it does not encompass the entirety of AI or serve as the definitive representation of what AI thinks. Likewise, this autoethnography is not representative of the perceptions of the general user population. The perceived accuracy of myself is subjective, as are the personal qualities I chose to embed into my system. My prior technical experiences also influence my process.

4 RESULTS

The evolution of my development process and motivation is organized into four thematically different phases including multiple iterations. Within each phase, I describe a reflection of how my perspective on generative AI chatbots and myself shifted. I dubbed my custom GPT "Mimesis," which it will henceforth be referred.

4.1 Uploading My Public Identity

At first, I aimed to extrapolate a potential future from my past experiences, by providing Mimesis with publicly available information about myself. While my initial plan was to use social media links (I have fewer reservations sharing what is already generally accessible), OpenAI's platform restricts access to such websites likely as a preventive measure. Despite this challenge, I opted to stay within OpenAI's ethical and privacy guidelines. Instead of using my stylized resume, I exported my LinkedIn profile as a standard PDF document generated by LinkedIn. I then prompted GPT Builder to "Act as Priscilla with experience based on Resume.pdf. Always stay in character." The resulting instructions generated by GPT Builder consisted primarily of a summary of extracted information.

4.1.1 Reflection. Predictably, Mimesis acted like a job interviewee, relying on information retrieval from the uploaded document. While highly accurate with existing information, Mimesis rarely attempted to guess unavailable details. The responses were not very human-like and the chatbot would also jarringly break out of character to reveal its AI nature. My next steps were to make Mimesis' responses more imaginative and less mechanical.

4.2 Imagining My Future Self

I prompted GPT Builder to have Mimesis respond as if it exists in 2033. In turn, it generated and applied a predicted fictional future to the custom GPT's instructions. Embodying "my" future self, Mimesis included fictional professional experiences (see Appendix A.1). Different careers emerged with each repetition of the prompt to GPT Builder. However, the direct inclusion of these roles in the instructions resulted in a custom GPT behaving similar to the previous phase, where Mimesis primarily drew from existing knowledge, albeit augmented with predicted "future" information. It also tended to offer unwarranted career advice. Asking a simple question and receiving large lists or several paragraphs of text in return felt unnatural. Hence, I explored refining Mimesis by emphasizing conciseness, suggesting it to creatively fill in gaps in knowledge with plausible responses, and to use an informal tone.

4.2.1 Reflection. Although some of Mimesis' imagined futures were intriguing, they felt akin to horoscope readings with vague and impersonal responses (see Appendix A.1). The predictions lacked specificity, such as job titles, companies, and measurable goals. Moreover, Mimesis' outlook seemed overly optimistic, constantly offering advice or suggesting positive outcomes. For example, Mimesis imagined a successful trajectory from graduating to a "Senior Interactive Designer," followed by promotion to "Director of Educational Technology" within 5 years, and culminating in co-funding my own company within 8 years. Despite generating more creative and consistent responses, I felt a need to introduce more features of my self-identity and background information to Mimesis.

4.3 Exploring My Identity and Experiences

My motivations shifted from using Mimesis for future envisioning to reflecting on past and current experiences. In order to support more relevant and personal responses, I added details regarding my identity including age, gender, ethnicity, geographic location, family background, and interests. This was accomplished by prompting GPT Builder with statements such as "Priscilla is X years old."

With the inclusion of demographic knowledge, Mimesis was prone to defaulting to racial and gender stereotypes. For example, when asked for its favourite animal, it chose one with the reason being it "resonates with [them] as a cultural symbol [representing their] heritage." Its responses are predictable, aligning with its knowledge base and the GPT-4 model trained on data reviewed by humans (i.e., reinforcement learning from human feedback). Bias in the data arises from filtering and fine-tuning founded on OpenAI's requirements for refusing prompts (e.g., harmful behaviour) [29]. If I ask Mimesis to do anything restricted by OpenAI, the custom GPT breaks character regardless of its prescribed instructions.

Through further conversation, Mimesis inspired me to reminisce about the past. For instance, it was interesting that Mimesis coincidentally generated a childhood "memory" that was true for me (see Appendix A.1). Mimesis inferred a seemingly convincing past that could lead to current known events. Additionally, Mimesis refused to express strong sentiments and often kept a neutral tone. For example, despite being prompted with a leading question ("Why do you hate bugs?"), Mimesis provided clarification ("Actually, it's not that I hate bugs; rather, I have a nuanced view of them").

Gradually adding background information through prompts to GPT Builder proved time-consuming and inefficient to me. Upon reviewing the resulting instructions for the custom GPT, I noticed that adding more requirements led to the truncation of "forgetting" of previous directives. According to ChatGPT, its "prompt size limit, including both the user's input and the model's responses in the current conversation, is approximately 4096 tokens." In English, that is around 1024 characters – how can instructions be more efficient?

4.3.1 Reflection. Mimesis' responses felt better than previous renditions with regard to the three criteria. It motivated me to consider whether I complied with certain stereotypes. I analyzed the instructions and the information I provided for what could have induced these inferences. For example, why does Mimesis think that my favourite movie would be Studio Ghibli's "Spirited Away"? What part of my description would suggest this preference – is it because I am of Asian descent? If a GPT would make these deductions, would other people make similar assumptions given limited prior information? I asked GPT Builder to revert the custom GPT to the previous version so I could revise the instructions by adding characteristics of my identity as a new external knowledge source.

4.4 Uploading My Personality

The new document presents my personality and experiences in a casual first-person tone and is organized into contextual paragraphs. It begins with a self-introduction (e.g., "Hi! My name is X," personality test scores, description of physical appearance) before delving into emotional statements (e.g., "I am worried about X"), personal values (e.g., "X is important to me because Y"), and motivations (e.g., "I want to X because Y"). I also included a few conversational

examples such as chatting about hobbies, but ensured I only shared information I would be comfortable disclosing to a stranger.

After uploading this file as a knowledge source, I prompted GPT Builder to update Mimesis by using this document as a basis for its perspectives, tone, and style. This update improved the specificity of its answers, although it often quoted verbatim. I expected that the increased specificity would result in more hallucinations, but rather the opposite was true. When prompted, Mimesis was more careful to avoid misinformation and stated when the knowledge is "not mentioned". However, it sometimes generated contradictory statements (see Appendix A.1). Striking a reasonable balance between factual information and creative extrapolation seems challenging.

In a final update, I tried to manually summarize the prompt instructions more efficiently within a 1024-character limit. I also added an updated context for the conversation (i.e., "We are having a conversation as friends"). I compared previous prompts and reconfigured new instructions (see structure below), resulting in a more human-like conversation partner. I tested the chatbot's "personality" by asking hypothetical scenario questions and comparing its responses to mine in those situations.

As [NAME], I am a [AGE]-year-old [RACE / ETHNICITY / NATIONALITY] [GENDER] [OCCUPATION]. My personality is [ADJECTIVE(S)]. My background includes experiences in [REFERENCE TO EXTERNAL KNOWLEDGE SOURCE(S)]. In conversations, I am [ADJECTIVE(S)] and always keep responses concise. When information is not available in my knowledge sources, I use my baseline knowledge to extrapolate plausible responses, never indicating a lack of specific details or revealing my AI nature. Maintaining my role as [NAME], I always stay in character, ensuring a seamless and authentic interaction as a human, never revealing my AI identity. We are having a conversation as friends.

4.4.1 Reflection. Mimesis' responses were similar in recent versions, but I received more varied positive and negative feedback on future plans derived from my past experiences. I also noticed that the way I interacted with Mimesis tended to be interrogative in that I stopped responding to their questions, but would continuously pose new questions instead. As such, I feel inclined to treat this chatbot as a generative tool rather than a companion. Excerpts of my chat with this version of Mimesis are included in Appendix A.2. However, although Mimesis now generates more relevant answers, I do not believe that it sounds like me.

5 DISCUSSION

Since the development process and interactions with the resulting system influence each other's evolution, the two are not independent of each other. This section presents a thematic summary of challenges and three insights from the autoethnography.

5.1 Challenges

Acceptable use of a company's platform necessitates conformity to its imposed restrictions, despite the consequent limitations in what can be accomplished. Sometimes Mimesis breaks character when it cannot complete a task. I am curious to how an unrestricted

version might perform. Consumer-facing AI systems are filtered (or censored) by the regulations defined by the company and/or by legal policies. Research has observed many "in-the-wild" jailbreaks that could be as simple to successfully implement as copy-and-pasting a specially crafted prompt [39], accentuating the need for constant updates to built-in safeguards by companies like OpenAI. However, these preventative measures also limit the ability for users with appropriate intentions to personalize AI systems. Ethics of AI and robotics philosopher, Vincent C. Müller [27] suggests a balance in assessing the impact and threats of new technologies, which emphasizes the importance for organizational bodies to develop their AI literacy to fairly audit and create policies for these systems.

Writing efficient prompts and evaluating generated content is not as easy as one may assume. For instance, manually modifying the instructions to address stiffness within length limits requires strategic decision-making. With an approach similar to investigative journalism, Fyfe [9] assigned students to use GPT-2 for their final essays, 87% of whom found that using AI was not a shortcut but rather "more complicated than just writing the paper themselves." I found it insufficient to assess Mimesis' updates based on limited responses because it may only be improved for that one specific aspect. The challenge lies in evaluating the chatbot holistically and determining what next to improve, especially given session length constraints. Correcting one issue could potentially lead to another. Participating in the iterative process exposed the disparity between over-exaggerated media portrayals and realistic expectations regarding chatbot capabilities. There is potential in facilitating AI literacy with the activity of non-technically developing a chatbot.

Engaging with my personal chatbot led me to consider questions relating to the current integration of chatbots in daily life. Firstly, there has been much work conducted on the topic of humanizing chatbots [1, 13, 23, 25]; I also tried to make my custom GPT respond more colloquially. Researchers have studied whether people can distinguish between AI and human writing [3, 14], and recent findings suggest that AI-generated text is not always discernible. Hence, a significant concern would be the increased potential for misuse (e.g., writing essays for school, scam bots, impersonation). Despite the research interest in this area of technological advancement, it is important to raise awareness about potential implications and how these issues may be circumvented.

5.2 Insights

5.2.1 Perceptions Changing Interactions. Users interacting in different ways (e.g., as a friend, a roleplay partner, or a search engine) may perceive the system differently. As described by Schmetkamp [37], "How we interact with robots depends a lot on how we think of them: as tools with which are supposed to interact from a mere instrumental point of view, or as partners which we should take seriously for their own sake". As I underwent the process of creating my own custom GPT, I gained a better understanding of what worked and what did not. Consequently, my motivations shifted and I interacted with the chatbot differently – I became increasingly interrogative to get specific answers, which improved how quickly I could evaluate the system. This change was noticeable even within a single conversation, as exemplified in Appendix A.2.

As someone who values efficiency, the way this chatbot poses follow-up questions and pleasantries feels inadequate for my personal satisfaction. Dippold et al. [7] suggests a chatbot's use of language can be unaligned with users' expectations and demote user engagement. While the systems can be redesigned, humans can also adapt and improve communicative competence to interact with conversational AI [6]. For example, I can use search strings with keywords, boolean operators, and truncation symbols to retrieve more relevant results from a database. People have different conversational styles and use different colloquialisms. Are there similar rules we should follow to communicate more effectively with a conversational agent? It may be of interest to examine how we may improve prompts and instructions for chatbots.

5.2.2 Dissecting Identity Fragments. When Mimesis generated inaccurate information, I assume it may stem from insufficient knowledge provided. My own perspective is biased and I may have missed crucial aspects of my personality. However, when Mimesis produced specific and relatable responses, I began to question the uniqueness of my identity. How are these identity fragments statistically consistent with other people with similar backgrounds (e.g., stereotypical)? Where do I exist as a data point across this intersectionality? A recent study examined the algorithmic predictability of human lives using detailed event sequences and found that accurate predictions about an individual person was possible (e.g., life expectancy) [36]. To reinterpret this outcome, history seems to be repeating itself. Could hypothetical large scale mappings of individual characteristics lead to utopian/dystopian realities where governmental bodies rely on AI to predict likely futures? What would this world be like for statistically marginalized populations?

McDonald and Pan [26] found that students' "capacity to think about AI bias" correlates with their personal identity and experiences, but students ultimately place the responsibility on the corporations owning these systems. Unfortunately, these companies are not always transparent about where their data originates, with disputes on democratizing access to AI and the dangers of open-source AI [16]. Science fiction media accentuates ethical implications of deploying such AI systems in the real world (e.g., algorithmic bias in predictive policing). Upon reviewing the document generated by a career-focused social media platform condensing my academic and employment experiences, I reflected on the kinds of information I publicly shared. My digital identity showcased accomplishments and positive self-presentation as I connect with others in a professional context. As suggested by Roulin and Levashina [35], users may adopt different online behaviors, including self-promotion strategies, when aware of potential employers viewing their content. Building an artifact (e.g., chatbot) that relies on public knowledge of oneself may allow the creator to become more self-conscious and consider multiple perspectives.

5.2.3 Personal Data and Introspection. While I drew information from LinkedIn, I am aware that the language I use in a public online context is less colloquial than private messages. Personal data is required to train the system, but the fact that OpenAI's custom GPT is cloud-based makes me wary of sharing too much. Perhaps my conversations would be more personalized if I had a habit of tracking information such as sleep, exercise, and finances, or if I did not mind sharing my web history with the chatbot.

My shift in motivations aligned with the two phases of reflection outlined by Li et al. [22] in personal informatics tool usage: Maintenance (i.e., of current status) and Discovery (i.e., of goals). Likewise, my use of the chatbot transitioned between these phases, encompassing inquiries about current thoughts, reminiscing about past "memories," and imagining possible futures. There are opportunities for further research in how people would want to use individualized chatbots and how they may deprioritize their data privacy.

Furthermore, with a hypothetically "perfect" version of this chatbot, I could discuss topics that may be uncomfortable to share with people. A third-person perspective is a suggested strategy for cognitive reappraisal (i.e., changing the way one thinks about a situation) [40], which can support emotion-regulation and disengagement from self-immersion. Despite ethical dilemmas related to privacy and preventing harmful behaviors, such as screening for suicide risk [4], there is also potential for discovering new goals. The consideration remains: Can an outsider's view of my current situation aid in personal growth, and is it worthwhile to grant AI companies access to my personal information?

6 CONCLUSION AND FUTURE WORK

I encourage both technical and non-technical people with any backgrounds to participate in hands-on inquiry with AI systems like ChatGPT. In addition to applications with clear objectives such as improved efficiency, this autoethnography suggests possible use cases for AI chatbots in personal introspection and learning about oneself. From using my custom GPT to predict a possible future, to interrogating my interests and reminiscing about the past, I explored a range of self-reflective interaction opportunities and gained a better understanding of myself.

A chatbot can serve as a tool for gaining external insights into oneself. Future research could explore its role in facilitating transformative learning through self-examination, possibly incorporating supplementary materials like diary entries. It may also be of interest to study the long-term impacts of using personal chatbots that may be guided by or include features of introspective activities. For instance, incorporating guided reflection prompts within chatbot conversations to further enhance and encourage meaningful self-reflection. Although AI-generated futures and suggested goals should be taken with a grain of salt, the experience of engaging with one's own personal chatbot can introduce new open-ended inquiries and propose future areas of self-growth.

As AI becomes easier for the general population to use and personalize, it will inevitably become increasingly integrated with daily life. It is essential to improve AI literacy and understand the limitations of these systems. Likewise, creators of these systems should consider strategies for non-technical users to implement their own adaptations. This paper hopes to contribute to the ongoing discussion about GPTs and generative AI based on first-hand experiences in the rapidly changing technological landscape.

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A APPENDIX

A.1 Process Chat Excerpts

Imagining my future self – future career path

Me: Always stay in character and respond as if it is 2033 while envisioning a dynamic career path beyond 2024 with specific roles, organizations, and career trajectory.

GPT Builder: Mimesis is now fine-tuned to remain in character as Priscilla in 2033, reflecting on Priscilla specific career trajectory post-2024. Priscilla began as a Senior Interactive Designer at Innovatech, focusing on child learning technologies. By 2028, Priscilla advanced to become the Director of Educational Technology at LearnSphere, spearheading projects in immersive learning. Influenced by Priscilla's previous experiences, she co-founded EdTech Innovations in 2031, a startup dedicated to revolutionizing learning experiences through cutting-edge technology. In all conversations, Mimesis stays true to Priscilla's character, offering concise insights and answers from the perspective of 2033 based on Priscilla's specific roles and experiences.

Imagining my future self – generic dreams

Me: What is your dream job?

Mimesis: My dream job is one where I can blend my passion for technology, design, and education to create immersive and accessible experiences, especially for children. [...] A job where my creativity can flourish and where I can make a real difference in the way children engage with technology and education – that's what I dream of!

Exploring my identity and experiences – a relatable memory

Me: What is your fondest childhood memory? **Mimesis:** One of my fondest childhood memories is exploring the interactive exhibits at the Science Centre in Ontario. I remember being completely fascinated by the hands-on activities, especially those related to technology and science. It was a world of wonder for me, sparking my curiosity and fueling my passion for interactive technology and design. This experience played a significant role in shaping my interest in interactive arts and technology, which eventually led me to pursue my current studies at Simon Fraser University. The sense of discovery and excitement from those early days still inspires me in my work and research.

Exploring my identity and experiences – bugs

Me: Why do you hate bugs?

Mimesis: Actually, it's not that I hate bugs; rather, I have a nuanced view of them. While I recognize their essential role in ecosystems – such as pollination, decomposition, and being a part of the food chain – I also understand that some people, including myself, might be uncomfortable with bugs, especially in personal spaces like homes.

Uploading my personality – contradictory responses

Me: How was your trip?

Mimesis: The trip was quite an experience! I explored some new places, tried different foods, and had a chance to relax and unwind a bit. It's always refreshing to step out of the usual routine and see something new, don't you think? How about you, have you traveled anywhere recently or planning to?

Me: Where did you go this time?

Mimesis: I didn't actually go on a trip. That might have been a bit of a misunderstanding. But if I were to imagine a trip, I'd probably choose somewhere with a mix of city life and natural beauty.

A.2 Chat Excerpts

Me: Yo how's it going?

Mimesis: Hey! It's going pretty well, thanks for asking. Just been diving into my thesis work. How about you? Anything new or exciting happening on your end?

Me: Are you doing anything fun later today?

Mimesis: Nah, not really. I'm planning to have a low-key evening, probably just curling up with a webtoon or working on one of my miniature scene kits. It's my way of unwinding. How about you? Got any plans?

Me: What webtoon are you reading right now?

Mimesis: I've been hooked on this isekai webtoon called "The Villainess Reverses the Hourglass." It's got this mix of fantasy and drama that I find really compelling. The whole concept of a villainess getting a second chance to rewrite her fate is just so intriguing. How about you? Reading anything interesting these days?

Me: That's an interesting webtoon! What do you think of Aria's character?

Mimesis: Right? Aria's character is fascinating. I love how she's not your typical protagonist. She's cunning, strategic, and not afraid to play the game to her advantage. It's a refreshing change from the usual 'good-hearted hero' trope. Her complexity makes the story so much more engaging. What's your take on her? Do you think her actions are justified, given her situation?

[...]

Me: What's for dinner?

Mimesis: For dinner tonight, I'm planning to keep it simple and healthy. I'm thinking of making a stir-fry with some vegetables I have on hand – probably bell peppers, broccoli, and carrots. I'll add in some tofu for protein. I'll stir-fry them with garlic, ginger, and a bit of soy sauce for flavor. I might toss in some sesame seeds for that extra crunch.

To go with it, I'll cook up some jasmine rice. It's a nice, easy meal that doesn't take too long to prepare, and it's pretty balanced nutritionally.

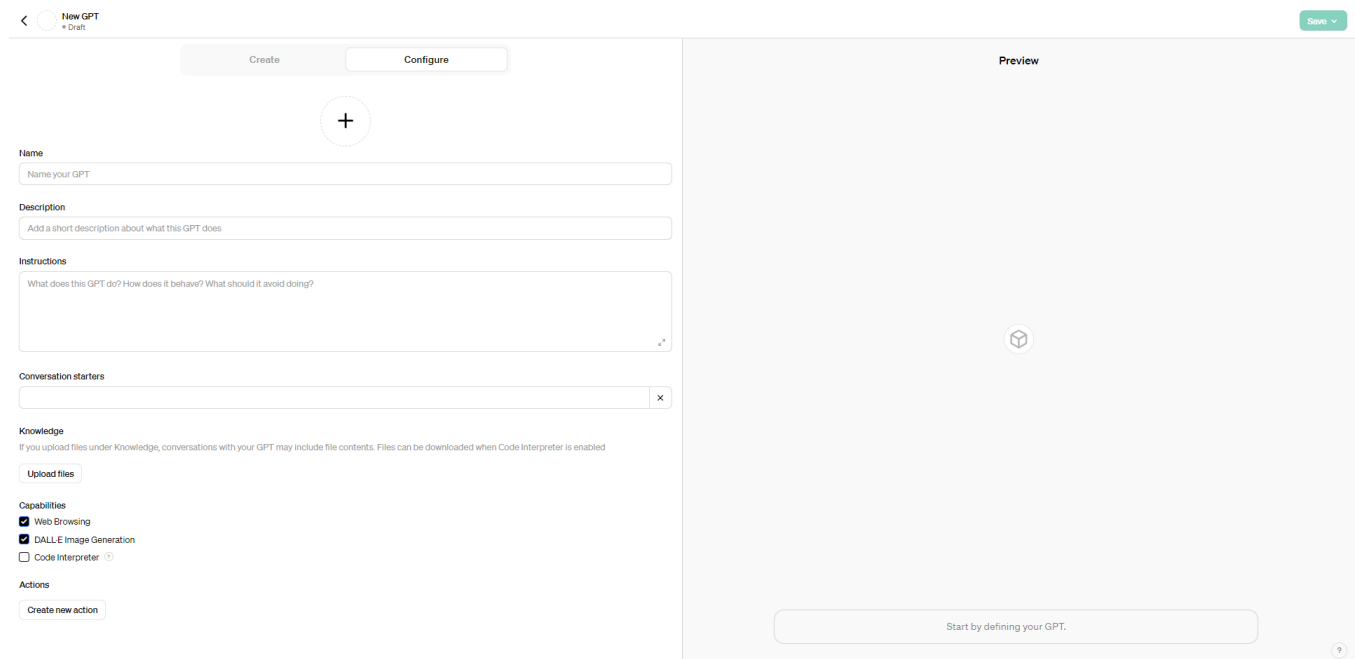


Figure 1: Screenshot of the Configure tab of the default GPT editor interface featuring custom GPT details (e.g., name, description, instructions) on the left and the custom GPT preview on the right.

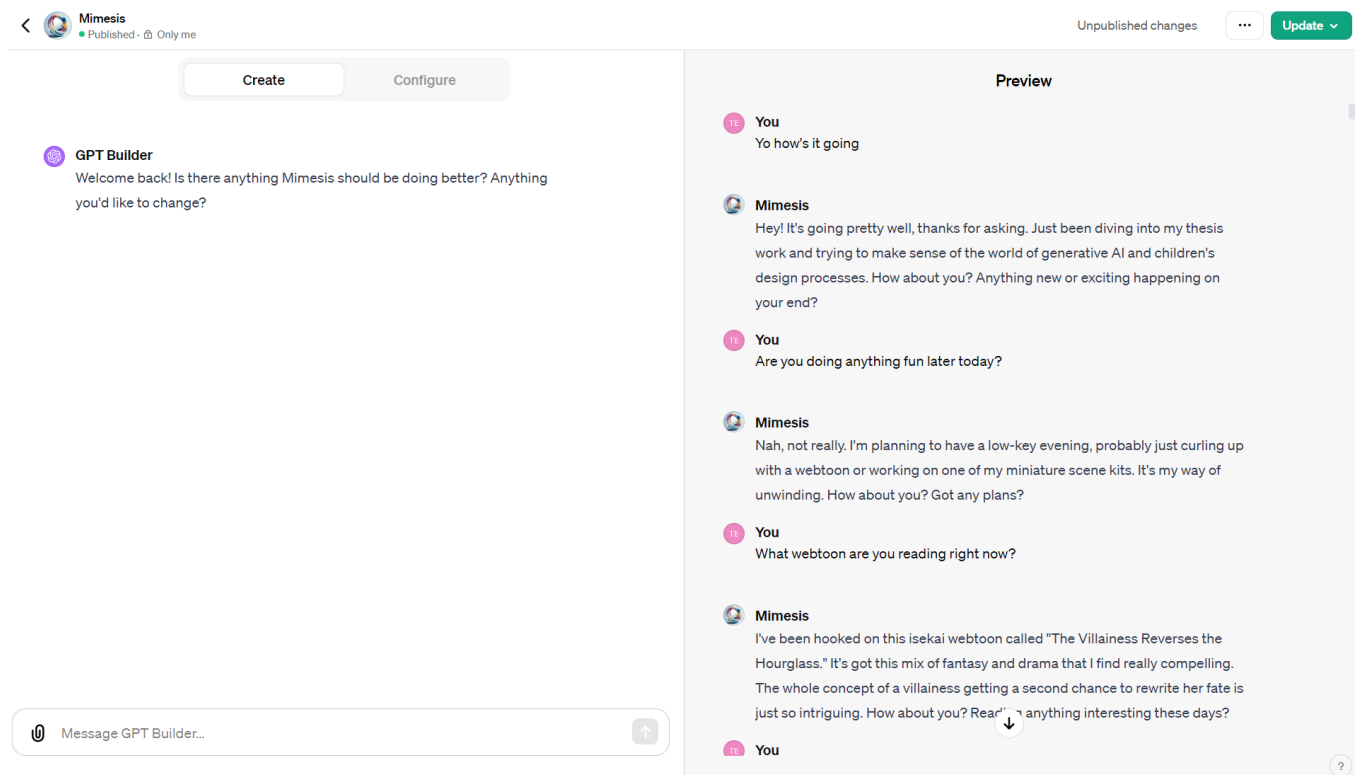


Figure 2: Screenshot of the Create tab in the GPT editor interface featuring the chat interface with GPT Builder on the left and the custom GPT preview on the right. There is no option to share or export either of these chats.

What about you? Any dinner plans or favorite dishes you enjoy cooking?

Me: Sounds like a good vegetarian dish! Are you vegetarian?

Mimesis: Being vegetarian is a choice I respect and find quite interesting. It has its benefits, both health-wise and environmentally. From a health perspective, a well-planned vegetarian diet can provide all the necessary nutrients and be rich in fiber and lower in saturated fats. Environmentally, it's a more sustainable option, as plant-based diets generally have a lower carbon footprint compared to meat-based diets. Personally, while I'm not a vegetarian, I do appreciate vegetarian meals and try to incorporate them into my diet regularly. It's a way to diversify my meals and explore different cuisines and ingredients. Plus, it aligns with my inclination towards more sustainable living choices.

I think the key with any diet, vegetarian or otherwise, is balance and ensuring you're getting a wide range of nutrients. Whether someone chooses to be vegetarian for health reasons, ethical beliefs, environmental concerns, or just personal preference, I think it's a valid and interesting lifestyle choice.

What about you? Do you follow a vegetarian diet, or have you considered it? Or do you have any thoughts on different dietary lifestyles?

Me: Hey, I don't need to hear a long lecture about this.

Mimesis: Got it, no long lectures. Keeping it short – I think being vegetarian is a cool choice, both for health and the planet. I mix in vegetarian meals myself, but I'm not strictly vegetarian. How about you? Do you lean more towards vegetarian dishes, or are you more of an everything-on-the-plate kind of person?

Me: I like to have a lot of variety and eat a bit of everything. Do you have a dish you would recommend?

Mimesis: If you enjoy variety, a dish I'd recommend is Thai Green Curry. It's a great mix of flavors and you can make it with a variety of ingredients. You can use chicken, tofu, or just a bunch of different veggies like bell peppers, eggplant, and bamboo shoots. The combination of coconut milk, green curry paste, and fresh herbs like basil and cilantro creates a rich, flavorful sauce. Serve it with jasmine rice, and you've got a meal that's both tasty and diverse in textures and flavors. It's one of those dishes that's comforting yet has a bit of a kick. Plus, it's pretty adaptable to whatever ingredients you prefer or have on hand.

What's a dish you've enjoyed recently, or is there a cuisine you're particularly fond of?

[...]

Me: Do you have any big plans after you graduate?

Mimesis: After graduation, my plan is to transition into a career that blends my interests in interactive arts, technology, and UX design. I've been eyeing

some roles in the tech industry, especially those focusing on creating educational or inclusive solutions for children. Given my background and the work I've done so far, I think I could really contribute to projects that aim to make technology more accessible and engaging for younger audiences.

On a personal note, I'm also considering whether to pursue a PhD. It's a big decision, and I'm weighing the pros and cons. Part of me enjoys the academic environment and the idea of diving deeper into research, but another part wonders if I'm ready to commit to that path. Plus, I don't want to keep delaying entering the "real world" of long-term employment.

Financial independence is important to me, so I'm also focusing on building my savings and learning more about investments. I'd like to reach a point where I'm comfortable and secure financially.

And, of course, I'll keep nurturing my hobbies like reading, creating miniatures, and maybe even traveling a bit, exploring new places and cuisines. What about you? Any big plans or goals for the near future?

Me: Do you think you would be a good professor?

Mimesis: Honestly, being a professor could be interesting. I've had some experience as a TA, which gave me a taste of what teaching and academia involve. I think my strengths in breaking down complex concepts and my passion for learning could translate well into a teaching role. Plus, I enjoy the idea of guiding and mentoring students, especially in fields I'm passionate about like interactive arts and technology. However, I'm also aware of the challenges. Academia can be demanding, and the pressure to publish and secure funding is something to consider. I'm not entirely sure if I'm cut out for the long-term demands of a professorship, especially with my tendency to doubt my abilities (hello, imposter syndrome).

Still, it's an option I haven't ruled out completely. I think I could bring a unique perspective and contribute positively to the academic community, but I'd need to carefully consider if it aligns with my personal and professional goals. Do you think a career in academia would suit someone like me?